



BRITTANY FRANCE

Crêpes in Cornouaille

Reaching out into the wild Atlantic and dotted with prehistoric megaliths, the granite peninsula of Brittany has an elemental mystery. In the ancient Celtic region of Cornouaille, residents take as much pride in its distinct culture as in its signature dish – the *crêpe*. The Bretons have elevated these simple golden disks, filled with seafood or smeared with honey or lemon, into an art form.



The humble pancake occupies a revered place in Brittany, where delicate, wafer-thin *crêpes* have been a way of life and an essential ingredient of gatherings since medieval times. *Crêpes* certainly rule in Quimper, Brittany's oldest city and the capital of Cornouaille, an historic region that was first settled in the Middle Ages by Welsh and Cornish Celts fleeing from the Anglo-Saxon invasion of Britain. They named this region in the southwest of Brittany "Cornouaille", the same as one of the places they had left – Cornwall.

Brittany became part of France in 1532, but Quimper still has much to show of its Breton history. Cobble streets lined with 14th-century timber houses still bear the names of the trades that once thrived there: rue Kêrêon was full of shoemakers, rue des Boucheries housed butchers, and the Place au Beurre was the place to buy butter. In July every year the town celebrates its Breton culture and heritage in the Festival de Cornouaille, drawing musicians, dancers, and visitors from Celtic communities around the world.

Beyond Quimper, Cornouaille's coast of dramatic cliffs, sheltered bays, and sandy beaches beckons fans of watersports along with walkers and cyclists. The

region has long been a favorite of painters escaping Paris in summer, and in the 1860s a cosmopolitan colony of artists sprang up in Pont Aven, a coastal village southeast of Quimper. It included the celebrated Post-Impressionist artist Paul Gauguin, who immortalized the Bretons in his paintings. The Inn of Marie Henri in neighboring Le Pouldu still features walls covered in works by the artist and his followers.

Crêpes provide the perfect counterpoint to any activity in Cornouaille, functioning as a snack, meal, or dessert according to the size and filling. There are two main varieties: true *crêpes*, which are made from white wheat flour, milk, and eggs; and *galettes*, made from buckwheat flour, salt, and water. Some insist the batter be beaten with a wooden spoon, while others add local Breton cider and skip the milk, but everyone agrees on the need for a tiny wooden rake (a *rozell*, or *rouable*) to spread the batter onto a hotplate, and a spatula (*spanell* or *viroué*) to flip it. Traditionally, *galettes* are savory – a classic is topped with ham, grated cheese, and a softly fried egg nestling in the middle – while *crêpes* are usually vehicles for sweet treats, such as hazelnut cream or strawberry jam. But the joy of these pancakes is their endless variety, which allows modern tastes to play with a 15th-century classic.

Three Days in Cornouaille

Wild surfing beaches, sandy seaside resorts, lively markets, and fishing villages with wonderfully fresh seafood vie for attention with walled towns and the Breton interior with its fascinating Celtic heritage.

DAY ONE Ramble around **Quimper's** charming old town, taking in the twin-spired **St. Corentin Cathedral**. Visit the **Breton Museum** to learn how Celtic and Breton folklores intertwine. Anyone with a penchant for pottery will love the **Musée de la Faïence**, with its 2,000-strong collection of centuries-old ceramics.

DAY TWO Drive or catch a bus to **Locronan**, one of France's most beautiful villages. Sacred to the Celts, it was a sail-making hub in the 16th century and its granite houses have inspired many a movie director, including Roman Polanski, who filmed *Tess* (based on Thomas Hardy's novel *Tess of the d'Urbervilles*) here in 1979.

DAY THREE Follow the **Painters' Trail** (using guides from the tourist office in Quimper) to see how and where the artists lived and what inspired them.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Regular **trains** run from Paris to Quimper. **Car rental** is essential to explore the region.

WHERE TO STAY

Hôtel Gradlon (inexpensive) offers cozy rooms near downtown Quimper. www.hotel-gradlon.fr
Les Sables Blancs (moderate) is a stylish hotel perched on the Bay of Concarneau.

www.hotel-les-sables-blancs.com

Domaine de Kerbastic (expensive) is a boutique hotel in a pretty château 40 minutes from Quimper. www.domaine-de-kerbastic.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

www.quimper-tourisme.com

